Jainism

Jainism is a religion of India whose ideal is the realization of the highest perfection of the nature of man, which, it holds, was in its original purity free from all pain and the bondage of life and death. The term Jain is derived from Sanskrit *jina* (victor, conqueror) and implies conquest over this bondage, which is imposed by the phenomenal world. Jainism does not consider it necessary to recognize any higher being other than the perfect man, and for this reason it is usually said to be atheistic. It can also be called a heretical sect of the Vedic faith, which had its origin in revolt from the tradition and the authority of the Vedas; its earliest founders may have belonged to the sect that rebelled from the idea and practice of taking life prevalent in the Vedic animal sacrifice. Jainism as a religion has predominantly monastic leanings, though its teachings are enjoined on all alike. Its peculiar genius lies in its emphasis on equal kindness toward all life, even toward all life, even toward the meanest; it is par excellence a religion of love and kindness.

Jainism has never been torn by philosophic dispute, but in the 4th or 3rd century B.C. the Jains began to split into two sects on points of rules and regulations for monks, a rift which was complete at least by the end of the 1st century A.D.

The Digambara (sky-clad, naked) hold that a saint should own nothing, not even clothes; hence the practice of going naked. They also believe that salvation is not possible for women. The Shvetambara (white-clad) differ from them on all these points.

LITERATURE

According to the Shvetambara, the sacred literature preserved orally since Mahavira was systematized and written down by the council at Pataliputra (Patna) about the end of the 4th century